

Responses to the Massachusetts Voter Table Questionnaire for US Senate Candidates - Joseph Kennedy

The Massachusetts Voter Table is a coalition of nonpartisan nonprofit organizations dedicated to increasing civic engagement in our commonwealth.

1. How do you plan to expand and protect voting rights, immediately in response to COVID-19 and permanently after the public health emergency?

In response to COVID-19, I'm proud to have been leading the charge to implement vote-by-mail for all elections in Massachusetts. No voter should be forced to stand in long, crowded lines in the middle of a public health crisis to practice their constitutional right to vote. And no one should be denied access to the ballot box for fear of jeopardizing their health and safety. I've advocated for mailing a ballot to every registered voter in the Commonwealth, and I've worked with the Massachusetts Legislature to advance legislation to do so. While vote-by-mail is critical in the short-term during this public health emergency, it is also a necessary step to expand and protect voting rights permanently after the immediate crisis subsides.

Beyond vote-by-mail, I also support automatic voter registration, same-day voter registration, extending early voting periods, and making Election Day a national holiday. We need to end voter purges and partisan gerrymandering, while removing restrictions that limit access to the ballot box -- that includes fighting back against efforts to expand voter ID laws and re-enfranchising formerly incarcerated individuals who have served their time. Expanding voting rights must include campaign finance reform to get money, special interests, and corruption out of our politics and protect the voices of individual voters. And finally, I support implementing Ranked Choice Voting and abolishing the Electoral College to ensure equal weight to every American's vote in our presidential elections.

2. What is your position on reparations for Black and Indigenous people in Massachusetts and in the United States?

I support reparations for Black and Indigenous people here in Massachusetts and across the country. We, as a nation, must recognize the role that the federal government has played -- and continues to play -- in enforcing and perpetuating systemic racism and

discrimination, take responsibility, issue a formal apology, and implement concrete actions to begin to repay BIPOC for generations of stolen rights, dignity, opportunity, and wealth.

I'm a proud co-sponsor of H.R.40, legislation in the House of Representatives that would create a commission to study the best way to implement a reparations policy and produce recommendations for Congressional action. I'm committed to dismantling systemic racism and fighting for racial justice across all facets of our federal systems, and will be proud to push for reparations as a member of the U.S. Senate.

3. How does race impact the distribution of environmental benefits and burdens in Massachusetts?

Nationwide and here in Massachusetts, environmental benefits and burdens are distributed disproportionately by race and socioeconomic status as a direct result of systemic racism and discrimination in federal, state, and local policymaking.

Communities of color, immigrant communities, and low-income communities disproportionately bear the burdens of environmental hazards, pollution exposure, adverse health effects, and vulnerability to the threats of climate change. Black families are [more likely](#) to live in neighborhoods with worse air pollution than white families -- even when they have the same or more income. Black and Latinx Americans see higher rates of childhood asthma -- a disparity that can have devastating effects, as seen in the current COVID-19 outbreak. And race is the most powerful predictor of where toxic waste sites are located in Massachusetts, which disproportionately burdens communities of color with adverse health consequences.

Meanwhile, whiter and more affluent communities tend to see the benefits of environmental protection efforts first -- from clean drinking water and clean air, to solar and wind energy, to green jobs and innovation. [Studies show](#) that the white and wealthy receive more federal disaster aid, even though they are most able to finally recover from a disaster.

As we transform our economy to achieve our climate goals, we must prioritize justice for the frontline communities whose health, safety, and wellbeing is most vulnerable. We need urgent action to reduce concentrated pollution in these communities, including by guaranteeing that everyone has access to clean drinking water, clean air, and can take part in the transition to clean energy. Frontline communities must have the federal support and resources they need to prepare, adapt, and respond to the inevitable effects of extreme weather and climate change. And finally, we must empower local

communities to address climate change through community-based initiatives, because it is critical that we bring voices from frontline communities to the table as we develop policies to protect our future.

4. What is your plan for providing permanent protection 11 million undocumented residents in the US?

I believe our country is made stronger, richer, and better by the contributions of immigrant families. I've seen firsthand the devastation of the Trump Administration's immigration policies, and I've been a leading national voice in efforts to block its horrifying agenda. I've made several trips to shelters and detention facilities along our border, and I've pushed the Administration for answers about dire medical conditions for children in detention, deaths of transgender migrants in detention, and the process for reunifying migrant children with their families.

I support comprehensive reform to create a fair, just, and humane immigration system. Comprehensive reform must include a reasonable and achievable pathway to citizenship for the 11 million undocumented residents already in the U.S.; ironclad protections for DREAMers and TPS recipients; compassion for refugees and asylum seekers; equitable access to work visas; and strategic investments in legal assistance, humanitarian aid, and effective, efficient border security. I've been proud to vote for the DREAM Act, which would provide protection from deportation and an opportunity to obtain legal status to young undocumented immigrants who were brought to the U.S. as children. Additionally, I believe we must decriminalize migration and make it easier for those seeking a better life in our country to do so legally.

5. At least 16,000 Southeast Asian community members who entered the US as refugees have final orders for deportation, many of which are based on old criminal convictions. What is your plan to address the prison-to-deportation pipeline?

To address the prison-to-deportation pipeline, we must first separate local law enforcement from ICE. We should prohibit state and local law enforcement agents from detaining individuals on behalf of ICE, notifying ICE regarding custody status or release, or sharing confidential information unless ICE can produce a valid warrant. This will reduce the interaction between the criminal justice system and ICE, while simultaneously enhancing local law enforcement protection for immigration communities, who may avoid reporting crimes to local police out of fear for themselves or their family members.

Second, we must deeply reform our immigration enforcement agencies to root out systemic abusive practices and reshape them to reflect our values as a nation of immigrants. They should be held to the same due process standards as other law enforcement agencies, and they should be reshaped to focus on homeland security efforts. To change the culture, we have to insist on transparency and strengthen the authorities of independent internal watchdogs to prevent future abuses.

Third, addressing the prison-to-deportation pipeline requires systemic criminal justice reform to end discrimination against immigrants and communities of color; reduce harsh sentencing requirements; and decriminalize poverty, mental illness, and homelessness.

Finally, I support ending the Trump Administration's cruel deportation policies and restricting deportations to only high-risk, convicted criminals and individuals who pose serious, credible threats. I also support eliminating the use of expedited removal proceedings and guaranteeing due process through hearings and access to legal counsel for those facing deportation.

6. What are your proposals to address the crisis of rental housing affordable to low-income people, including people experiencing homelessness?

Rising rents are displacing families from their homes and gentrifying our communities, leaving our lowest-income residents struggling to find even basic shelter. Our government has not done enough to address these serious housing challenges.

I've pushed the federal government to increase its investments into affordable housing programs that serve lower-income families, including expanding the Housing Choice Voucher rental assistance program. I support targeting these investments to help the communities that need them most, including communities of color, rural communities, and tribal communities. To bring down rents across the market, I support policies to build more housing, including more permanently affordable housing. Because legal representation is often the difference between keeping a roof over your head or not, I've fought to shore up legal assistance for families facing eviction. I'm proud to have introduced a resolution in the House that calls for a Civil Gideon, which would guarantee the right to counsel in civil legal proceedings, including eviction cases.

In response to the COVID-19 crisis, I called for a nationwide moratorium on evictions and foreclosures. I also joined my colleagues in the House in passing \$100 billion for emergency rental assistance as part of the HEROES Act, and I've pushed for additional

emergency funding to help our vulnerable residents here in Massachusetts make up missed rent and mortgage payments once the statewide moratorium is lifted.

To take on the epidemic of homelessness, I believe we must first stop treating homelessness as a crime. We must ensure that people experiencing homelessness receive the resources and services they need, rather than being forced into our criminal justice system. I've fought in Congress to guarantee equal access to shelters, preventing shelters from denying services to transgender or gender non-conforming individuals. And I've fought to reduce homelessness as a result of eviction by pushing for the right to legal counsel in civil legal cases and other crucial services that help prevent homelessness.

7. 69% of white families in Massachusetts own their home compared with only 32% of households of color. What specific proposals do you have to close the racial homeownership gap?

I believe housing is a fundamental right for all, and that few issues are more critical to our fight for true social, racial, and economic justice. Generations of racial discrimination by the federal government redlined communities of color and denied them access to homeownership subsidies available to white families. Skyrocketing housing costs, inequitable development, and persistent structural inequities are putting safe, healthy, and affordable homes out of reach for too many in Massachusetts. These challenges continue to prevent families of color from achieving homeownership today and contribute to widening the racial homeownership gap.

I'm a proud co-sponsor of legislation that would invest \$500 billion in our affordable housing supply, offer an easier pathway to homeownership, and tackle systemic racial discrimination in our housing markets. Specifically, this bill would give down-payment grants to first-time homebuyers who live in formerly redlined and segregated neighborhoods, while also making it easier for borrowers to find an affordable mortgage, no matter where they live. These policies are intended to reverse systemic racial discrimination in our housing systems and shrink the racial homeownership gap.

I also support policies to address state and local zoning rules that drive up the cost of construction, limit the opportunity to build new homes, and prevent families from living in the communities of their choice. And I've fought to prohibit all forms of housing discrimination by strengthening and fully enforcing our fair housing laws.

Finally, we must recalibrate our entire economy to remove the structural barriers that have allowed racial economic inequality to take root, to persist, and to keep entire

segments of our population marginalized. I advocate for wide-ranging economic reforms that will empower people of color to build wealth and access economic mobility. These reforms include, but are not limited to, a livable minimum wage, ironclad organizing and collective bargaining rights, robust protections against discrimination, progressive tax reform, federal support for minority-owned small businesses, equitable access to high-quality education, and universal access to health care and child care. Only by deliberating dismantling systemic racism throughout our country and our policymaking will we be able to close the racial wealth gap that contributes to and exacerbates the racial homeownership gap.